UPFRONT

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GRAPHIC: REACHING FOR THE MOON *PG 14*



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MOVING ON Nitish files RS nomination papers as BJP's Amit Shah and deputy CM Samrat Chaudhary look on, Patna, Mar. 5

▶ BIHAR BJP

EXIT NITISH, ENTER BJP

With the JD(U) colossus moving to the Rajya Sabha, Bihar may be witnessing a historic political transition—the fading of Mandal-era dominance and the beginning of a saffron one

By ANILESH S. MAHAJAN and AMITABH SRIVASTAVA

WHEN NITISH KUMAR FILED HIS NOMINATION FOR THE RAJYA SABHA ON MARCH 5, Bihar's political universe shifted irrevocably. A sitting chief minister taking such a step was unheard of, more so since it came barely four months into his tenth term. The momentous decision signalled two things: the sunset of a four-decade political era in Bihar shaped by Mandal-era social justice politics, and the fact that the balance of power was tilting heavily in favour of ally BJP.

For over three decades, the patriarch of the Janata Dal (United) has been the pivot around which Bihar's coalition politics revolved. His alliances—switching between the BJP, Lalu Yadav's Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) and regional partners—repeatedly redrew the state's political map. But through all these shifts, the CM's chair always remained his since he first occupied it in 2005. Now, the BJP sees an opportunity that has been decades in the making—a chance to instal its first CM in Bihar. Party sources say talks are on with JD(U) leaders on the modalities of the new government, with